

« BEFORE

Sparsely populated and weakened by centuries of decline, Cambodia and Laos offered little resistance to the imposition of French colonial rule.

FORMER GLORIES

Whereas Vietnam was shaped by Chinese Confucianism, Cambodia and Laos belonged to the Indian Hindu-Buddhist cultural sphere. **Cambodia** had been the site of the **Khmer empire** in medieval times, but all that remained of such glories by the 19th century were the ruins of Angkor Wat. Preyed upon by its more powerful neighbors Vietnam and Siam (Thailand), **Cambodia welcomed a French protectorate** in 1863. The country was integrated into **French Indochina** in 1887, while remaining nominally under the rule of its traditional monarchy.



CAMBODIA'S ANGKOR WAT

EMBATTLED LAOS

By 1779, **Laos** was split between rival kingdoms that were dependencies of Siam. During the 19th century, **Vietnam and Siam fought for control of the region**. The French established a protectorate in Laos in 1893 and integrated it into French Indochina in 1898, although a Laotian king remained on the throne in the north at Luang Prabang.

In the spring of 1945, during their wartime occupation of French Indochina, the Japanese gave nominal independence to Cambodia and Laos under their traditional rulers. King Norodom Sihanouk declared Cambodia's independence from France in March 1945 and King Sisavang Vong followed suit in Laos in April.

Moves by nationalists